HOME CARE | OCTOBER 2026

Self-Managed Care in Alberta

A plain-language guide to getting home care funding and hiring your own workers

The short version

Self-Managed Care (SMC) is publicly funded home care where the money comes to you instead of a worker coming to you. You receive funding, and you hire, pay and manage your own care workers.

It is not a benefit cheque. It is a one-year agreement between you (or your legal representative) and the province, with conditions, and it makes you an employer, with payroll duties to the Canada Revenue Agency (CRA).

For the right household it can change everything. For the wrong one it can be a heavy load. This guide helps you tell which one you are.

Who runs it now

Self-Managed Care used to sit under Alberta Health Services (AHS). It is now run by **Assisted Living Alberta (ALA)**, the provincial agency for continuing care. In practice that means:

- The official brochure is still posted on the AHS website (albertahealthservices.ca), but it now says "Assisted Living Alberta" on every page. It is marked "Updated: September 2026."
- Your agreement is with Assisted Living Alberta.
- You start by calling the **ALA Access Centre** (number on the last page).

So if you search "AHS self-managed care" you will find the right papers, but the people you deal with work for ALA.

Who can get Self-Managed Care

The brochure says anyone living in Alberta with a health care card, and living in a community setting (your own home, not a facility), can be eligible. You must also:

- have "assessed unmet health care needs within ALA Provincial Home Care Service Guidelines"
- have "stable health and predictable care needs"
- need "ongoing personal care and home care support services (e.g., longer-term needs)"
- be "willing and able to assume the responsibilities and risks" of contracting your own care

That last point is a real test. If you cannot take it on yourself, the brochure says "a legal representative may do this on behalf of a client." That is the route for a family supporting an adult with a disability, or a parent with dementia.

There is no age limit in the eligibility list. SMC is not only for seniors, even though most information about it is filed under seniors.

Three ways to get home care

Most people are never shown all three side by side. Ask your case manager which one you are being offered, and which ones you qualify for.

	Regular home care	Client Directed Home Care Invoicing (CDHCI)	Self-Managed Care (SMC)
Who chooses who comes?	ALA arranges the workers. You do not choose.	You choose an agency from the Alberta Blue Cross list of registered providers.	You choose and hire the person.
Who is the employer?	ALA or its contracted provider.	The agency.	**You** (or your legal representative).
Who handles payroll and taxes?	Not you.	Not you. The agency bills Alberta Blue Cross directly.	**You.** Payroll, deductions, CRA business number, Alberta employment standards.
How much control?	Least	Middle	Most
How much work for you?	Least	Middle	Most
Where is the rate written?	Not applicable to you.	ALA sets a maximum hourly rate. It is stated in your Alberta Blue Cross letter.	Comes from your assessment and your agreement. Not published.

Under CDHCI, if you want more hours than ALA approved, or an agency that charges more than the ALA maximum, you pay the difference yourself (CDHCI brochure, September 2026).

What the money can pay for

Services are "based on your home care assessment." They include:

- **Personal care:** hygiene, dressing, toileting, moving and transferring, eating, oral care and medication management
- **Home support:** help preparing meals, homemaking, and recreation activities
- **Respite:** day, evening or night care to give an unpaid caregiver (usually family) a break

What it cannot pay for

The brochure says: "Self-managed care funds cannot be used for any other purposes." Professional services such as nursing, social work or therapy "cannot be purchased with self-managed care funds but will be arranged by the home care case manager, if needed." So if you need them, ask your case manager. They come from a different budget.

The rule that catches everyone

You cannot pay family members or friends with Self-Managed Care funds. The brochure says:

> *"Family members, friends and informal caregivers are not allowed to be hired as paid care providers."*

People hear "you hire your own workers" and assume they can finally pay the daughter who has been doing the work for years. Under SMC, you cannot. Every worker must be legally allowed to work in Canada.

You can also hire a private home care agency, as long as the worker is employed by the agency.

What you take on

Signing an SMC agreement makes you an employer. The brochure lists your responsibilities. You, your loved one, or their legal representative must:

- recruit, interview, hire, train, supervise and schedule your workers, and direct their work
- have a back-up plan for when a worker cannot come at short notice
- evaluate your workers and, when needed, end their employment
- manage wages and payroll
- send ALA reports every quarter (every three months) confirming how the funds were spent
- meet CRA rules, for example registering for a business number and taking income tax, Canada Pension Plan and Employment Insurance off workers' pay
- meet Alberta employment standards for every worker
- tell your ALA home care case manager **within 72 hours** of any change in health, care needs or living arrangements, such as a hospital stay
- keep proof of authority on file if a legal representative is acting (for example a guardian, trustee, agent under a personal directive, or attorney under a power of attorney)

The agreement is signed for a one-year term.

The payroll piece is the part people most often underestimate. Before you say yes, ask your case manager how quarterly reporting works, and plan who will run payroll.

How to apply, step by step

These steps come from the Assisted Living Alberta "Getting care" page.

1. **Anyone can ask for an assessment.** You do not need a doctor's referral. Family, friends or a health care provider can also reach out for you.
2. **Get ready.** Have your health care card number, address and contact information. If you are calling for someone else, have their contact information too. A health care provider will contact them directly.
3. **Call the ALA Access Centre: 1-855-371-4122.** Monday to Friday 8:00 am to 6:00 pm. Weekends and holidays 8:00 am to 4:00 pm.

4. **The assessment.** A Case Manager meets with you to work out your needs. If you live at home, it happens at home. If you are in hospital, a member of the health care team does it there.
5. **After the assessment.** Your Case Manager shares the results with you (and, with your permission, your family or legal representative) and talks about the level of care that fits.
6. **Ask about Self-Managed Care by name.** It is one option among several. If nobody mentions it, say the words.

Other ways in

You can also start through your family doctor, nurse practitioner or Primary Care Network, or through the hospital team if you are in hospital.

What the assessment looks at

The Assisted Living Navigation Portal lists six areas. Knowing them ahead of time lets you prepare instead of being asked cold.

1. Thinking and communication	memory, decision-making, hearing and vision
2. Emotional and social well-being	mood, behaviour, social supports
3. Daily function and independence	mobility, self-care, continence
4. Health and medical needs	diagnoses, medications, treatments
5. Nutrition and physical health	oral health, nutrition, skin condition
6. Environment and safety	your home and safety concerns

Tip: for each area, write down a real example from a hard day, not a good day. What happens when no one is there to help? How long does it take? What goes wrong?

The money, and why you cannot look up the rate

No public SMC rate. As of October 29, 2026, the Self-Managed Care brochure published no dollar amount, hourly rate or table. Your funding comes out of your assessment and your agreement.

The CDHCI rate went up on October 1, 2026. Alberta Blue Cross told home care agencies in its September 2026 provider bulletin that, "Effective October 1, 2026," claims are paid "at the updated hourly rate of $35.03." It applies to all services, including weekends and statutory holidays.

ALA sets that rate. The CDHCI brochure refers to the "ALA maximum hourly rate as stated in your Alberta Blue Cross letter." The Alberta Blue Cross provider guide says the health system is "responsible for setting the maximum hourly rate."

What nobody has published: whether Self-Managed Care funding went up on October 1 too, and whether anyone was told. CDHCI clients get their rate in a letter, and agencies get a bulletin. We found no written route that tells SMC clients when their rate changes.

Protect yourself

- Keep a copy of your SMC agreement and **every** approval or renewal letter. They are your only dated record of what you were entitled to.
- Check your deposits against your agreement every month.
- If something changed and nobody told you, ask in writing. Our fill-in letter on the website asks ALA exactly what your rate is, whether the October 1, 2026 increase applies to you, from what date, and for a copy of the program manual.
- If anyone helps you run payroll, give them a copy of any rate letter you receive. They are not part of your agreement, so ALA may not tell them.

What the law says, and does not say

We read the three continuing care laws on the King's Printer website on October 29, 2026: the *Continuing Care Act* (current as of December 18, 2025), the *Continuing Care Regulation*, AR 21/2024, and the *Continuing Care (Ministerial) Regulation*, AR 44/2024 (both current as of August 27, 2025).

The words "self-managed" do not appear in any of them. The rules for Self-Managed Care live in the brochure and in your agreement. That makes your agreement the most important paper you have. Read it, keep it, and ask for anything you do not understand to be explained in writing.

Who to call

ALA Access Centre (start here, all of Alberta)	1-855-371-4122 Mon to Fri 8:00 am to 6:00 pm Weekends and holidays 8:00 am to 4:00 pm
Continuing Care Access, Edmonton Zone (intake)	780-496-1300
Assisted Living Alberta general questions	ask@assistedlivingalberta.ca
Health Link, 24 hours	811
Emergency	911

What we are still checking

- Whether the October 1, 2026 rate increase applied to Self-Managed Care, and from what date.
- Whether ALA has any duty to tell SMC clients in writing when their funding rate changes.
- What ALA's Provincial Home Care Service Guidelines say. That is the document the eligibility test runs on, and we have not found it published.
- The Self-Managed Care Program Manual. A dementia resource site says home care gives it to SMC clients, but we have not seen it. If you are on SMC, ask your case manager for a copy and keep it with your agreement.
- How to ask for a review if you disagree with an SMC funding decision. Until we confirm the process, ask your case manager for any decision in writing, with the reasons and how to have it reviewed.

If you are on SMC and have a letter showing a rate change, a renewal letter, or an answer from ALA, we would love to see it with your name and numbers covered.

Sources

- Assisted Living Alberta, *Self-Managed Care* brochure, "Updated: September 2026," posted at albertahealthservices.ca/assets/info/seniors/if-sen-self-managed-care-brochure.pdf. Read October 29, 2026.
- Assisted Living Alberta, *Client Directed Home Care Invoicing* brochure, September 2026, albertahealthservices.ca/assets/info/seniors/if-sen-gen-cdhci-brochure.pdf. Read October 29, 2026.
- Assisted Living Alberta, *Getting care*, assistedlivingalberta.ca/page14301.aspx, and *Home & community care*, assistedlivingalberta.ca/page14279.aspx. Read October 29, 2026.
- Assisted Living Navigation Portal, *Self-managed care*, alnavigator.alberta.ca. Read October 29, 2026.
- Alberta Blue Cross, *Provider Benefact* BE012-0044 2026/09, "The Client Directed Home Care Invoicing (CDHCI) program: 2026/2027 rate change," September 2026. Read October 29, 2026.
- Alberta Blue Cross, *CDHCI provider program guide*, ab.bluecross.ca/pdfs/CDHCI-provider-program-guide.pdf. Read October 29, 2026.
- *Continuing Care Act*, SA 2022 c C-26.7 (current as of December 18, 2025); *Continuing Care Regulation*, AR 21/2024, and *Continuing Care (Ministerial) Regulation*, AR 44/2024 (both current as of August 27, 2025). King’s Printer, read October 29, 2026.

This guide is information, not legal or financial advice. Rules change. Check the date at the top before relying on anything here.